

Multicultural Immersion Experience

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COU 5283 : Counseling in a Multicultural Setting

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May 2, 2025

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Being able to submerge myself into a multicultural experience is something I had not thought of doing up until taking this course. Throughout the semester I was taught valuable lessons for my daily life but also, as a future counselor. Becoming a counselor means understanding your clients cultural background along with their life experiences that have shaped them into who they are. Trying to understand their culture, beliefs, and values is essential to build the rapport in the client-counselor relationship. It also allows for counselors to understand clients on a deeper level because culture is such a significant aspect of an individual's life. Being informed on culture can also help understand communication styles, perception of mental health, and their coping mechanisms whether it is individualistic or family oriented. This course has taught me that cultural competence is an ongoing process and culture curiosity should always be present.

Synopsis of the Experience

The multicultural experience took place on March 31, 2025, at 2:00 p.m., at the residence of Muhammad Hashim. During this time, I was welcomed inside and greeted with home-made food and treats from their place of origin - Malaysia. I was able to sit down with the family members and have a conversation about our own cultures and how delicious the food they had provided was. We shared laughs about their kids' stories of moving to the States and being an immigrant myself - I could relate to the feeling of the unknown but also be understandable of their experiences. After we had lunch, I had the honor to accept the request of having henna drawn onto my hand. The experience was amazing because I had not been able to experience this but also, I never dared to since I was afraid of cultural appropriation because I did not understand

the significance or the history behind it. However, being invited to participate made this experience truly meaningful and for that, I am thankful.

Reason for Choosing the Experience

The reason I chose the Muslim Community as an immersive experience is because I have always been curious about their language, culture, beliefs, and experiences. However, growing up there was not cultural diversity within my community or school which restricted my access to getting to know different cultures. Having the opportunity to immerse myself in a community that I have always wanted to learn about. During this experience, I was able to understand a different way of living that is totally different from my own culture. Being able to understand their cultural background, values, norms, and beliefs was inspiring and motivating. With this knowledge I can continue to grow as a future counselor but also be aware of my own biases and assumptions regarding cultures that are different from my own. Cultural curiosity is extremely important when it comes to becoming a counselor. To provide the best approach and being conscious of our client's background experiences allows the counselor-client relationship to blossom and build rapport. It is also a learning experience that allows time to ask meaningful questions and be comfortable with diversity.

What I Learned About the Respective Population

During the experience, I had the pleasure to talk to the family and get insight of their perspective on counseling, the challenges faced as a community migrating to the states along with some impactful comments that stuck with me. During a conversation, I was taken back when a sibling stated "Mental illness is not a thing, it doesn't get diagnosed. It is swept under the rug." This statement was extremely devastating because I can think of many adults, teenagers,

and children going through hardships that affect their mental health but can't be talked about because it is seen as a weakness or taboo. Many individuals seek support within their family and prayer can also be used as a coping strategy. Seeking help will also be seen as “bringing shame” into the family and destroying their honor and reputation. Regarding seeking help outside of their cultural group, that is another challenge itself - they were vocal on being afraid of not being understood because their culture and experiences are different from those not born in Malaysia. It also comes with many trust issues regarding immigration and how much they can speak about without the counselor being mandated to report an instance. Attending therapy for mental health wellbeing was also discussed to be a luxury rather than obtainable and resourceful for everyone. It can be expensive to attend a session and/or not within appropriate distance for individuals who have no transportation. Practicing this religion also comes with many challenges such as stereotypes and misconceptions that can prevent individuals from seeking mental health services. A few misconceptions/stereotypes talked about were that “they are all traditional, women stay home and do not have an education.” These stereotypes bring a lot of distrust to people outside of their community and feel judged by non-Muslim counselors. Addressing these concerns are important to be able to build a client-counselor relationship based on trust and be able to provide that safe environment they are seeking. It also reduces self-stigma that prevents individuals from asking for help because of negative thoughts such as “I am weak”. Providing an environment where every individual feels heard, safe, and not judged is the goal for a therapeutic session to keep growing.

What I Learned About Myself

Reflecting on my own biases and assumptions through this experience has been challenging. One of my assumptions was that individuals born in Malaysia identified as Arab

and that is not the case. I quickly learned that Malaysia is not an Arab country, and their official religion is Islam. Arab countries are those in the Middle East and North Africa now categorized as MENA in the U.S census. To acknowledge and become aware of this misconception was important for me because I would not have known without proper research. Moreover, this could potentially risk my relationship with my future clients. Becoming culturally competent is essential when it comes to all ethnicities, races, and religions to try and understand where the client is coming from. I was disappointed in myself at one point for realizing that it was quick to make assumptions with no research from my part.

I also learned that although Islam the official religion of Malaysia, not every household is Muslim, many are also Christian. Assuming someone's religion because of their ethnicity was an eye opener - religion connects to people in different ways and assuming an individual's beliefs should never be the case. I am looking forward to learning more about cultures, beliefs, and language along with history because generational trauma is extremely impactful in counseling and how feelings can come up but also how a person chooses to cope with negative experiences, thoughts, and feelings.

Implications for Culturally Sensitive and Competent Counseling

Throughout this experience, I was able to understand that even though a culture might have similar beliefs, ideas, and customs it doesn't equate that their community follows the same cultural norms. Every individual is different because of circumstances, life experiences, and challenges they've faced. To become a culturally competent counselor, one must accept and acknowledge that it's a continuous journey. An approach I will develop is humanistic with integrative and explore what works best for my client. I have learned that there is no one-size-fits

all theory approach and finding out what works best for our clients is essential. I would like to practice a humanistic and person-centered approach because it allows one to connect with one's own emotions and look at past emotions. Whereas other techniques focus primarily on the present and future disregarding that past experiences can influence a person's feelings, actions, and beliefs. Building rapport comes by creating a safe space for clients to talk about their experiences and feelings. By connecting to their emotions, I can continuously grow the foundation of trust.